

BALLET is a pantomime telling a story in dance and music. The ballet is often introduced in an opera or stage piece aided by spectacular scenery and costumes. It is not necessarily part of an opera but may be complete in itself. "Dance of the Hours" is a classic ballet which was written for the opera "La Gioconda" by Amilcare Ponchielli, an Italian composer, who was the teacher of Puccini. The opera was first performed in Milan, April, 1876.



Radio City Music Hall Corps de Ballet

The scene is laid in Venice in the 17th century. La Gioconda, a beautiful street singer, is loved by Barnaba, a spy; but she spurns him because she is in love with Enzo, a Genoese nobleman. In revenge, Barnaba incites the people against Gioconda's blind mother, accusing her of witchcraft. The mother is saved by Enzo who, having incurred the displeasure of the "council," is obliged to disguise himself as a fisherman. In Act 3, the great hall of the Ducal Palace is filled with masqueraders for the ball. The Duke announces the ballet in which the dancers, costumed as the Hours of Dawn, Day, Evening, and Night, portray the struggle between day and night. In the finale, the hours of light conquer the hours of darkness.

PHRASING: Ability to phrase gracefully is absolutely necessary to good piano playing. It not only adds style to your playing but also gives life and animation to the music.

Preparatory Exercise



Dance of the Hours

Ponchielli (1834-1886)

Moderato

p lightly and gracefully

poco rit.

a tempo

mf

pp